VERMONT

The Green Mountain State



Vermont has never been a place that wastes anything—not land, not labor, and certainly not food.

By the early 1800s, the Green Mountain State had established itself as one of the most productive agricultural regions in the young nation. The hillside farms of Addison County and the Champlain Valley were thick with apple orchards, many of them planted by the region's earliest English and Scottish settlers who understood instinctively that an apple tree, once rooted in Vermont's rocky glacial soil, would outlast nearly everything else they built. Varieties like the Baldwin, the Northern Spy, and the Rhode Island Greening thrived in the cold, and by harvest season the cellar shelves of every farmhouse from Middlebury to St. Johnsbury were stacked with bushels saved against the long winter ahead.

Cheese was equally woven into the fabric of Vermont life. The same settlers who planted the orchards also kept dairy herds, and the making of sharp cheddar became a deeply practical art. Cheese kept. It traveled. It sustained farmhands through long days in the field and fed families through February when fresh food was a memory. The cheesemaking traditions brought over from England's Somerset and Cheshire counties took hold in Vermont soil just as firmly as the apple trees had, producing a sharp, crumbling cheddar that became the pride of the region's farm wives and creamery operators alike.

It was in the farmhouse kitchens of central and northern Vermont that the two came together. After a long harvest day, with the wood stove burning and the smell of browning butter crust filling a low-ceilinged kitchen, a wedge of sharp cheddar laid alongside a warm slice of apple pie was simply practical—protein and sweetness, salt and fruit, the farm's two greatest offerings sharing a plate. Women like those who kept households in the hill towns of Washington and Orange counties were not cooking for elegance. They were cooking for hungry people, and the combination was as logical as it was delicious. The sharpness of the aged cheddar did for apple pie exactly what a squeeze of lemon does for fish—it cut the sweetness, deepened the flavor, and turned something familiar into something you couldn't stop thinking about.

By the late 1800s, the pairing had become so associated with New England identity that it appeared in regional cookbooks, country fair tables, and eventually the dining cars of New England railroads, where travelers heading north got their first taste of what Vermonters had known for generations. Some say the tradition is purely Yankee practicality. Others trace it to the English custom of serving fruit puddings alongside cheese, carried across the Atlantic and quietly naturalized in the Green Mountains. Either way, Vermont claimed it—and Vermont was right to.

This is the kind of dish that rewards you the moment it comes out of the oven. The filling bubbles at the edges, the crust catches a deep golden color, and when that first slice meets a cold, sharp slab of Vermont cheddar, something clicks into place that feels less like a recipe and more like a memory you didn't know you had. Make it once and you'll understand immediately why Vermonters never saw any reason to change a thing.

APPLE PIE WITH CHEDDAR CHEESE

In Vermont, the phrase "Apple pie without cheese is like a kiss without a squeeze" says it all.

Yield: One 9-inch pie

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INGREDIENTS

CRUST

- 2½ cups all-purpose flour
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 cup (2 sticks) cold unsalted butter, cubed
- 6–8 Tbsp ice water

FILLING

- 6 cups peeled, sliced tart apples (such as McIntosh, Cortland, or Granny Smith)
- ¾ cup granulated sugar
- ¼ cup brown sugar
- 2 Tbsp all-purpose flour
- 1 tsp cinnamon
- ¼ tsp nutmeg
- ¼ tsp salt
- 1 Tbsp lemon juice
- 1 tsp vanilla extract

TOPPING

- 1 egg, beaten (for egg wash)
- 1 Tbsp coarse sugar (optional, for topping)
- 8 oz. sharp Vermont cheddar, thinly sliced, plus wedges to serve

Historic Vermont baking leaned on Baldwin, Northern Spy, and Rhode Island Greening apples; this recipe calls for varieties more common in today's markets.

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Make the crust*: In a large bowl, whisk together flour and salt. Cut in butter using a pastry cutter or fingertips until mixture resembles coarse crumbs. Gradually add ice water, 1 Tbsp at a time, until dough comes together. Divide in half, form into disks, wrap, and chill for at least 1 hour.
2. *Prepare the filling*: In a large bowl, toss apples with sugars, flour, cinnamon, nutmeg, salt, lemon juice, and vanilla. Set aside to let juices develop, 15 minutes.
3. *Assemble the pie*: Preheat oven to 400°F (204°C). Roll out one dough disk and line a 9-inch pie plate. Add the apple mixture. Roll out second dough disk and place over the filling. Trim, crimp edges, and cut small slits for steam.
4. *Bake*: Brush top crust with beaten egg and sprinkle with coarse sugar if desired. Bake 20 minutes at 400°F (204°C), then reduce heat to 350°F (175°C) and bake another 35–40 minutes, until golden brown and bubbling. Cool the pie for at least 1 hour before slicing so the filling sets.
5. *Melt the cheese and serve*: Lay thin slices of cheddar over the warm pie (or over each cut slice) and return it to a warm oven or under a low broiler for a minute or two until it just softens and melts. Serve with a small wedge of sharp cheddar—or, if you prefer, a scoop of vanilla ice cream.

